



Grade 8
General
English Language Arts

Directions:

On the following pages of your practice test booklet are questions for the Grade 8 *Nebraska Student-Centered Assessment System (NSCAS) General English Language Arts* practice test.

Read these directions carefully before beginning the test.

This practice test will include several different types of questions. Some questions are based on a passage. Multiple choice questions will ask you to select an answer from among four choices. Multiple select questions will ask you to select multiple correct answers from among five or more answer choices. For some questions, there may be two parts, Part A and Part B, where each part has a multiple choice or multiple select question. Some questions will ask you to construct an answer by following the directions given.

For all questions:

- Read each question carefully and choose the best answer.
- You may use scratch paper to make notes.
- Be sure to answer ALL the questions.

The items on this page are not passage-based.

★ 1. Read the beginning of Myla's paragraph.

Movies based on books are hugely popular these days, especially for teenagers. It can be exciting to see the characters from a favorite book come to life on the big screen. However, not all teens appreciate or even like the movie versions of their favorite books.

What kind of information could Myla include in the paragraph to BEST support the topic?

- A. quotes from teens who go to a lot of movies
- B. the names of movies that will be released soon
- C. a list of popular books that would make good movies
- D. reasons why some teens dislike movies based on books

★ 2. Select the word in each pair that provides the BEST transition.

The tenure of Franklin D. Roosevelt was full of challenges and conflict, all of which he faced head on to become one of the greatest presidents in American history. First elected in the midst of the Great Depression, Roosevelt was able to pull the country out of economic devastation. (**Then, Additionally**) came the onset of World War II, a battle he was not able to avoid. Roosevelt's policies (**therefore, ultimately**) led to peace and prosperous times for the country.

Read the passage.

Feeling Like Home

- 1** The plane landed on the tarmac at the airport after an uneventful flight from San Juan. As they taxied to the gate, Mateo looked out the window at the strange landscape. He soaked it in, both eager and nervous to see his new home.
- 2** Uncle Damien met them at the baggage claim area and drove them to what was now home. The street in Queens where Uncle Damien parked was adjacent to the elevated train tracks. Mateo thought they only had subways in New York City, but as was obvious by looking at this overhead train system, he was wrong. As they got out of the car, the train rumbled and shook the earth as it careened past the station. Mateo thought to himself, “How are we ever going to sleep at night to this? It’s certainly nothing like the soothing sound of the ocean.”
- 3** Luckily for them, Uncle Damien had offered them a place to stay. His apartment had two small bedrooms and a rather large living room where Uncle Damien had set up a big curtain to separate it into two sections.
- 4** “That side is where you two will bunk.” He pointed to the bunk beds on one side of the curtain and motioned for Mateo and his younger brother Pedro to put down their bags. “Then, Ferdinand and Maria, this is your room,” he showed Mama and Papa to the apartment’s larger bedroom.
- 5** That night after they were settled, Uncle Damien showed them around the neighborhood. Tall brick buildings lined both sides of the street. Underneath the elevated train were shops, restaurants, and street vendors selling their wares. Mateo did have to admit that some of this did feel familiar—the smell of the food, the goods sold by the vendors, the music trailing out the apartment windows, all felt like home.
- 6** “Just about everyone who lives in this area came from Puerto Rico, or their families did,” Uncle Damien explained as they ate at one of Uncle Damien’s favorite Puerto Rican restaurants just a few doors down from their building. “In fact, some people like to call this Little San Juan. You can find Little Colombia, Little India, Little Santiago, Little Italy, Chinatown, and all kinds of other micro-neighborhoods in New York City. It is a fascinating place. I think you’ll grow to love it.” Mateo listened **skeptically**.
- 7** As Mateo tried to go to sleep on the bottom bunk later that night, he felt miserable. After one plane flight, everything in his life was new. Questions flew through his mind: How would he ever fit in here? Would the people here be nice to him? Would he be able to make any friends? It was so different. There was no ocean, no palm trees, no sandy beaches.

- 8 The next morning seemed to come in a flash, and Mateo hardly even felt like he slept at all. The train, the noise, the anxiety of the move—it had all taken its toll on any kind of restful sleep that Mateo could hope for. At least there was one constant in Mateo’s life: Mama always made breakfast every morning, no matter what.
- 9 “You look nice, Mateo,” Mama said as Mateo walked into the kitchen in his best clothes for school. “You nervous about today?”
- 10 “A little,” Mateo replied, not wanting to worry his mama. “I think it’ll be okay,” he said boldly, trying to convince himself more than anything else. He grabbed a plate and dished up a serving of tortilla Española and fried plantains.
- 11 Mateo trudged to school through the thick crowds of commuters, and before he knew it, he was walking into the two-story brick building on the corner of Jackson and 9th. As he walked down the hall of his new high school, he felt **apprehensive**. It wasn’t anything like his school back home, but how could it be?
- 12 After stopping by the office, Mateo leaned against a wall and looked down at his schedule. As he did, he heard two students walk past speaking Spanish in a Puerto Rican accent Mateo instantly recognized. Mateo spun around and called out a greeting to the students in Spanish. One nodded and the other gave a quick smile and wave. Mateo was thrilled to see them walk into the classroom where he was headed.
- 13 Even in this very different place, Mateo sensed he could someday feel at home. This new world had begun looking better already.

3. In paragraph 6, what does Uncle Damien’s description MOST emphasize about New York City?
- A. It attracts many tourists.
 - B. It has a large population.
 - C. It is a place of diverse cultures.
 - D. It is as beautiful as other cities.
4. Which quotation BEST shows that Mateo feels a sense of longing for his old home?
- A. Mateo thought they only had subways in New York City . . .
 - B. Mateo did have to admit that some of this did feel familiar . . .
 - C. After one plane flight, everything in his life was new.
 - D. There was no ocean, no palm trees, no sandy beaches.
5. What does **skeptically** mean as it is used in paragraph 6?
- A. angrily
 - B. doubtfully
 - C. excitedly
 - D. fearfully

6. Why does Mama MOST LIKELY make breakfast in the morning?
- A. to keep herself busy in her new home
 - B. to let Mateo experience something familiar
 - C. to give Mateo energy for the long walk to school
 - D. to help the family know what life in New York will be like
7. What does **apprehensive** mean as it is used in paragraph 11?
- A. confused
 - B. excited
 - C. nervous
 - D. relieved
8. Which sentence BEST states the theme of the passage?
- A. Sharing new experiences can bring families closer together.
 - B. Large cities can offer unique opportunities for personal growth.
 - C. Without close family connections, it is easy to lose a sense of community.
 - D. Though moving can be difficult, it is possible to find belonging in a new place.

The item on this page is not passage-based.

- ★ 9. **Ariannah is writing a research report about the American Revolution. Read the paragraph from her report.**

The American colonists were originally proud to be citizens of England. However, the large distance between the Colonies and the British government made them feel very far removed from England. When King George imposed several new taxes on the colonists, the gap widened. When American colonists decided to boycott British goods, the king sent British soldiers to the Colonies to keep the colonists in line. After the colonists carried out the Boston Tea Party, the king further angered them by passing a series of taxes and laws that became known as the Intolerable Acts. The colonists had had enough. They declared their desire for independence, and the start of the American Revolution soon followed.

Ariannah wants to add a sentence to the beginning of the paragraph. Which sentence would be the BEST introduction for the paragraph?

- A. The American Revolution started in 1775.
- B. Many different events led to the start of the American Revolution.
- C. The Boston Tea Party was an important episode in the American Revolution.
- D. The American Revolution is also known as the American War of Independence.

The item on this page is not passage-based.

- ★ 10. **Bowen is writing about Isaac Newton. Read the paragraph from a source he found.**

Although aircraft are modern inventions, the principles that explain how they operate were first expressed more than 300 years ago. Sir Isaac Newton, who was merely 23 at the time, proposed his theories of gravitation in 1666. Then, in 1686, his laws of motion helped scientists understand how force, velocity, and momentum change and interact. Though developed in the 17th century, Newton's laws are applied to aerodynamics, from airplanes to rockets.

Bowen wrote these sentences for his essay. Which sentence should he revise because it plagiarizes the source?

- A. Between 1666 and 1686, Sir Isaac Newton proposed laws and theories that impact modern sciences, like aerodynamics.
- B. Sir Isaac Newton's laws of motion, which were presented in 1686, concern force and velocity and relate to aerodynamics.
- C. Modern science benefits from the laws first expressed more than 300 years ago by Newton, who was merely 23 at the time.
- D. Although he never encountered an airplane or a rocket, Sir Isaac Newton developed theories that influence modern science.

Read the passage.

Ashfall Fossil Beds

- 1 In 1971, a paleontologist¹ made an important discovery in Nebraska. He found the fossil skeleton of a baby rhinoceros in a ravine. This discovery would have a large impact on science. Today, people can get a glimpse of this astounding discovery at Ashfall Fossil Beds State Historical Park.

Formation of the Fossil Beds

- 2 The region's climate was different millions of years ago compared to the climate of today. Air temperatures were warmer, and the air was more humid. Due to the climate, the plants and animals that **inhabited** the region were also different from those found there today. The climate, plants, and animals of Nebraska changed slowly over time. An **epic** event that occurred long ago saved a record of the prehistoric era.
- 3 Many scientists believe that there was a tremendous volcanic eruption in the region millions of years ago. The eruption released large amounts of ash into the atmosphere which spread into the air for thousands of miles before falling back to Earth. Animals inhaled the ash over a period of weeks and died. The remains of the animals and geographic features became buried in a layer of volcanic matter. The skeletons of entire creatures were protected and preserved in this volcanic ash. Over the years, they were fossilized.

Features of Ashfall Fossil Beds

- 4 Ashfall fossil beds are one location where many fossil skeletons have been discovered. Fossils are common and have been found all over the world. Ashfall fossil beds, however, are one of the few places where entire fossil skeletons have been found.
- 5 In 1991, Ashfall Fossil Beds became a Nebraska state historical park. This was an important step in an effort to protect and preserve the fossil beds. Scientists can continue their study of the fossils without the threat of land development.
- 6 The park also offers visitors an opportunity to see what wildlife existed in the region millions of years ago. It is a fascinating place where visitors can see fossilized remains of camels, giant turtles, saber-toothed deer, rhinoceros, and many other animals. The fact that there are so many complete, well-preserved fossils also makes the park an important scientific site.

Working at the Park

- 7** Ashfall fossil beds are a unique phenomenon. The location continues to be studied, even forty years after its discovery. More than 200 fossilized skeletons of twelve prehistoric species have been uncovered. Each fossil is carefully recorded and mapped in an effort to keep track of past and current finds. New discoveries are made every year.
- 8** The Hubbard Rhino Barn is a large building that houses and protects areas being studied. It is named after the huge number of rhinoceros fossils discovered at the site. Students from the University of Nebraska gain field experience by working there.

Touring the Park

- 9** Ashfall Fossil Beds State Historical Park is located in northeastern Nebraska. The park covers 360 acres of rangeland in Antelope County. Visitors to the park can enjoy hiking and picnicking. Trails throughout the park provide many scenic views of the valley and a glimpse of the region's geological features. The trails also allow people to view the wildlife and plants that are present today in the region.
- 10** At the Rhino Barn, visitors can observe paleontologists at work. A goal of the facility is to spark wonder in children and adults. For anyone with an interest in prehistoric life, fossils, or paleontology, a trip to Ashfall Fossil Beds State Historical Park would be time well spent.

¹paleontologist—a person who studies fossil remains

11. According to the passage, how are the fossils in Ashfall Fossil Beds connected to the ancient volcanic eruption?
- A. The eruption attracted scientists to the area, and those scientists eventually discovered the fossils.
 - B. The eruption caused the air to be warmer and more humid, creating ideal conditions for the formation of fossils.
 - C. The eruption released ash that killed animals and covered the remains, and those remains eventually became fossils.
 - D. The eruption exposed areas of the land where fossils were located, allowing them to be discovered and studied many years later.
12. What is the meaning of the root **-hab-** in the word **inhabited**?
- A. to bite
 - B. to live
 - C. to move
 - D. to protect
13. Which sentence from the passage BEST expresses how the author feels about the park?
- A. Many scientists believe that there was a tremendous volcanic eruption in the region millions of years ago.
 - B. Scientists can continue their study of the fossils without the threat of land development.
 - C. Visitors to the park can enjoy hiking and picnicking.
 - D. For anyone with an interest in prehistoric life, fossils, or paleontology, a trip to Ashfall Fossil Beds State Historical Park would be time well spent.

14. Read the sentence from paragraph 1.

“This discovery would have a large impact on science.”

Which **two** sentences from the passage BEST support this claim?

- A. The climate, plants, and animals of Nebraska changed slowly over time.
- B. The eruption released large amounts of ash into the atmosphere which spread into the air for thousands of miles before falling back to Earth.
- C. Ashfall fossil beds, however, are one of the few places where entire fossil skeletons have been found.
- D. In 1991, Ashfall Fossil Beds became a Nebraska state historical park.
- E. More than 200 fossilized skeletons of twelve prehistoric species have been uncovered.

15. **This question has two parts. Answer Part A, and then answer Part B.**

Part A

In paragraph 2, what is the meaning of the word **epic**?

- A. expected
- B. major
- C. temporary
- D. usual

Part B

Which words from paragraphs 2 and 3 BEST support the answer to Part A?

- A. Due to the climate . . .
- B. . . . occurred long ago . . .
- C. . . . tremendous volcanic eruption . . .
- D. . . . falling back to Earth.

16. **Read the sentence from paragraph 7.**

“The location continues to be studied, even forty years after its discovery.”

What idea does the sentence emphasize?

- A. how popular the park is for visitors
- B. how significant the park is as a scientific site
- C. how much scientists learn by working in the park
- D. how difficult it is to uncover the fossils in the park

17. Why does the author describe the trails in the park in paragraph 9?
- A. to highlight a feature that visitors can enjoy
 - B. to support the idea that the park is a unique place
 - C. to explain how the scientists access the fossil beds
 - D. to describe the places where the fossils are located
18. Which **two** sentences from the passage express the central ideas?
- A. Today, people can get a glimpse of this astounding discovery at Ashfall Fossil Beds State Historical Park.
 - B. The region's climate was different millions of years ago compared to the climate of today.
 - C. Fossils are common and have been found all over the world.
 - D. The fact that there are so many complete, well-preserved fossils also makes the park an important scientific site.
 - E. The Hubbard Rhino Barn is a large building that houses and protects areas being studied.

The items on this page are not passage-based.

- ★ 19. **Tae is writing about Earth Day 2018. Read his first paragraph.**

Since 1970, people have celebrated Earth Day on April 22. People around the world are involved in Earth Day activities each year, organized by the group earthday.org. Every Earth Day has a theme. In 2018, earthday.org decided to focus on stopping plastic pollution.

Tae wants to add a sentence to the end of the paragraph to provide a focus for the essay. Which sentence would BEST complete the paragraph?

- A. The group earthday.org is also known as the Earth Day Network.
- B. One of the organizers of the first Earth Day returned to help plan Earth Day 1990.
- C. I do my part to reduce plastic pollution by recycling plastic instead of throwing it away.
- D. They knew that educating people about the harms of plastic pollution would be one way to achieve this goal.

- ★ 20. These sentences are from a story Jess is writing.

Which sentence should Jess revise because it is a run-on?

- A. After realizing his math homework was due tomorrow morning, Jackson decided to stay home to work on it instead of going to the park to play soccer.
- B. Once he finished his homework, Jackson discovered that he still had time to play soccer in the back yard before dark.
- C. Jackson kicked the ball around by himself for a while, but two kids from next door eventually came over and joined the game.
- D. The game finished when it was too dark to see the ball, everyone was tired and hungry and ready to go inside anyway.

**NSCAS General Grade 8
Practice Test Answer Key
ELA**



Sequence	Key	Points
1	D	1
2	Then, ultimately	1
3	C	1
4	D	1
5	B	1
6	B	1
7	C	1
8	D	1
9	B	1
10	C	1
11	C	1
12	B	1
13	D	1
14	C, E	2
15	Part A: B Part B: C	2
16	B	1
17	A	1
18	A, D	2
19	D	1
20	D	1